RIDING UP A STORM

CYCLING EVENTS TO PREPARE FOR



CYCLE TOUR OF ARUNACHAL PRADESH
March 13 - March 19
(nnejourneys.com)

This cycle tour of Arunachal Pradesh will take you to the point where three of India's easternmost tributaries come together to form the Brahmaputra. That, though, in no way, is the only watershed moment on offer here. There are also vistas to see, tribes to meet and family-run eco-lodges to stay in.



AAMCHI MUMBAI CYCLOTHON 2022
March 27
(aamchimumbaicyclothon.com)

One of the first such events to be organised in the city, this 'cyclothon' aims to promote eco-friendly transport options, thereby helping create awareness about sustainable living among Mumbaikars.



MANALI-LEH + KHARDUNGLA CYCLING EXPEDITION
July 9 - July 19
(dare2gear.com)

Just reading the 11-day itinerary of this cycling expedition is a treat in itself. The journey from Manali to Khardungla has the most awe-inspiring pit stops—Keylong, Sarchu, Pang, Lato, and, of course, Leh.

SPORTS

The Bikepacker's Guide to the Galaxy

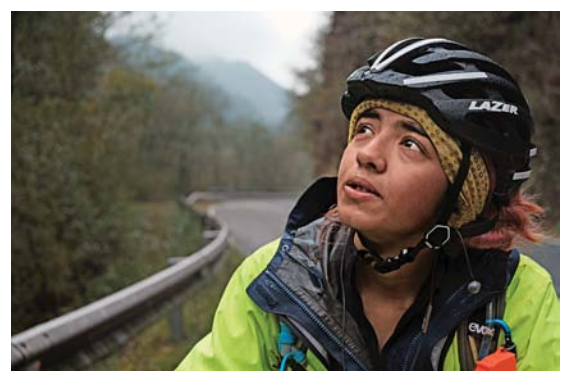


Bikepacking isn't easy, but several Indians are taking to it in an effort to discover the world and themselves

A year ago, Shriram Kondhawekar, 50, and Milind Tambe, 56, got together to plan their annual adventure. Most times, they preferred going on a Himalayan trek, but this time, they wanted to hit the open road and cycle along India's coastline. As they began to research, they realised just what they were up against—the distance added up to 6,800 km, with a total elevation gain of around 24,000 metres, which would take them 101 days in all to pedal. They would be riding self-supported, which meant carrying all the essential gear on their bicycles. "I last rode a bicycle during my college days. But Milind's idea was unique and I had enough self-belief that I could pull it off," says Kondhawekar.

Bikepacking or bicycle touring has increasingly become a popular mode of travel and exploration. At the heart of it is the joy of making unhurried progress each day. A photographer by profession, Navin Paul, for instance, wanted to travel at a pace that would allow him to capture the diverse landscape of India. His plan to live on the road for two years meant he had a tight daily budget of only Rs 300. He stayed in gurudwaras, cooked his own food, camped wherever possible, banking on the generosity of people on the road. "In Murudeshwar, I was approached by a fisherman. He warned me of robberies in the area and didn't let me camp on the beach. I slept in his small hut where he fed me fresh fish. It was a touching gesture from a complete stranger," Paul says.

AT THE HEART OF BIKEPACKING IS THE JOY OF MAKING UNHURRIED PROGRESS EACH DAY, TAKING IN THE SIGHTS AT LEISURE





SPINNING WHEELS
Vedangi Kulkarni (top); and Navin Paul

As a female cyclist, Vedangi Kulkarni faced a few challenges when she started a solo attempt to circumnavigate the world in 2018. "I had to deal with my periods on the go. I was unconsciously hiding my hair and looking out for anybody 'dangerous'," she says. The modest bicycle, in the end, mainly helped Kulkarni, now 22, befriend many a stranger. While looking for shelter during a thunderstorm in Elkhorn, US, she was hosted by a family, who even rode a short distance alongside her the next day. "The ride taught me that people are mostly good at heart and it's important that I see the good in them before the bad," Kulkarni says. ■

–Shail Desai